HCCS™

Human Capital Control Standard™

Core Standard

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Table of Contents

Executive Summary

1. Scope and Applicability

- 1.1 Purpose
- 1.2 Governing Principle
- 1.3 Scope
- 1.4 Applicability
- 1.5 Intended Audience
- 1.6 Non-Compliance Risk Statement
- 1.7 Out of Scope
- 1.8 Standard Boundary Statement

2. Normative References and Conventions

- 2.1 Normative Language
- 2.2 Regulatory Positioning
- 2.3 Professional and Scientific References
- 2.4 Versioning

3. Terms and Definitions

4. Core Thesis

- 4.1 Empirical Foundation

5. Maturity Model

- 5.1 Level Progression Requirements

6. Compliance Tiers

- 6.1 Qualified Assessors and Auditors
- 6.2 Compliance Period

7. Control Domains

- 7.1 RG: Role Governance
- 7.2 EI: Evaluation Integrity
- 7.3 DG: Decision Governance
- 7.4 AG: AI Governance
- 7.5 PI: Process Integrity
- 7.6 CG: Compensation Governance
- 7.7 ER: Evidence and Records Governance

8. Audit and Accountability

Appendix A: Control ID Index

Appendix B: Maturity Level Requirements Matrix

Appendix C: Regulatory Cross-Reference

Appendix D: Version History and Change Log

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Appendix E: References

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Executive Summary

Human capital decisions materially impact financial performance, operational risk, and legal exposure. Yet these decisions are typically made without formal controls. These decisions represent one of the largest ungoverned risk surfaces in the enterprise.

Organizations maintain financial controls to protect the integrity of financial decisions. Equivalent controls do not exist for human capital decisions. The result is a consequential decision system, one that determines who enters the organization, at what level, and at what cost, operating without governance, auditability, or accountability.

HCCS™ closes that gap.

The Human Capital Control Standard™ establishes a control and audit framework for role design, candidate evaluation, hiring decisions, compensation alignment, and AI usage across all human capital processes. It is not a hiring improvement model. It is a governance standard, structured for auditability, designed for certification, and built to exceed current regulatory requirements.

The problem: Most organizations treat hiring as a workflow rather than a decision system. Roles are poorly defined. Candidates are screened through weak proxies. Hiring managers apply subjective judgment shaped by bias. AI is being layered onto flawed processes, increasing speed without improving integrity.

The standard: HCCS™ defines 67 controls across 7 governance domains, a 5-level maturity model, and a tiered compliance framework that scales from self-attestation to third-party audit.

The audit principle: If the organization cannot reconstruct how a decision was made, what evidence it relied on, and whether standards were applied consistently, the process MUST be treated as unreliable.

The commercial threshold: Maturity Level 3 (Defined) is the minimum for external credibility. Organizations at this level have documented, communicated, and operationalized controls across all domains.

HCCS™ governs both hiring decisions and compensation alignment as a unified decision system. This distinguishes it from HR process frameworks, DEI programs, and AI-only governance models. The closest analogs are SOX (financial decision controls), NIST AI RMF (system risk governance), and ISO standards (operational consistency). HCCS™ sits across all three.

HCCS™ establishes that human capital decisions are not discretionary activities, but controlled processes subject to audit.

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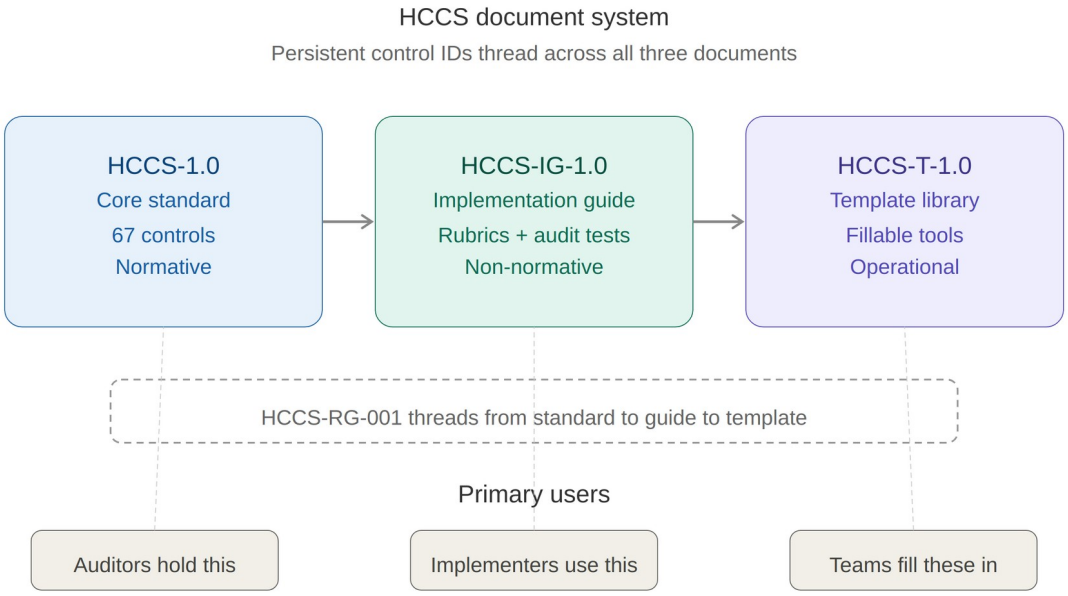

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1. Scope and Applicability

1.1 Purpose

HCCS™ establishes a governance and audit framework for human capital decisions. It defines controls for how organizations design roles, evaluate candidates, make hiring decisions, and align compensation to actual scope of work.

Human capital decisions materially impact financial performance, operational risk, and legal exposure. Yet these decisions are typically made without formal controls. The result is that consequential decisions about people are made through opaque, inconsistent, and indefensible processes.

1.2 Governing Principle

If the organization cannot reconstruct how a decision was made, what evidence it relied on, and whether standards were applied consistently, the process MUST be treated as unreliable for compliance purposes. This principle governs every control in this standard.

1.3 Scope

HCCS™ governs both hiring decisions and compensation alignment as a unified decision system. This standard applies to all human capital decisions involving:

- Role definition and design
- Candidate sourcing, screening, and evaluation
- Hiring and selection decisions
- Compensation determination and alignment
- Use of AI or automated systems in any of the above

1.4 Applicability

HCCS™ is role-type-agnostic. The controls defined in this standard apply universally across executive, professional, technical, operational, and hourly roles. Implementation examples vary by role type; the controls do not.

The standard is designed for adoption by organizations of any size, sector, or geography. Compliance expectations scale through the maturity model (Section 5) and compliance tiers (Section 6).

1.5 Intended Audience

This standard is intended for:

- Executive leadership (CEO, CFO, CHRO, Board)
- HR and People functions responsible for hiring and compensation
- Internal audit and enterprise risk management
- Legal and regulatory compliance

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- AI governance and data ethics teams
- External auditors and certification bodies

1.6 Non-Compliance Risk Statement

Failure to implement controls defined in this standard increases organizational exposure to inconsistent decision-making, systemic bias, regulatory non-compliance, compensation misalignment, and indefensible AI usage in human capital processes. These risks carry financial, legal, reputational, and operational consequences.

1.7 Out of Scope

This standard does not govern:

- Post-hire performance management or termination processes
- Labor relations or collective bargaining
- Benefits administration

These areas may be addressed in future versions or companion standards.

1.8 Standard Boundary Statement

HCCS™ governs decision integrity. It does not prescribe specific hiring tools, technologies, or methodologies, provided that the controls defined in this standard are satisfied. Organizations retain full discretion over implementation approaches.

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2. Normative References and Conventions

2.1 Normative Language

This standard uses three levels of requirement, aligned with PCAOB auditing conventions:

Keyword	Obligation Level	Definition
MUST	Unconditional	The requirement is mandatory at all maturity levels. Non-compliance at any tier constitutes a control failure.
SHOULD	Presumptively Required	The requirement is expected at Maturity Level 3 (Defined) and above. Departure is permitted only with documented rationale that demonstrates equivalent control effectiveness.
MAY	Recommended	The practice represents best practice and is expected at Maturity Level 4 (Managed) and above. It is not a compliance gate at lower levels.

2.2 Regulatory Positioning

HCCS™ is designed to exceed the requirements of current employment and AI regulations, including but not limited to:

- Title VII of the Civil Rights Act and EEOC enforcement guidance
- EU AI Act (high-risk AI classification for employment decisions)
- NYC Local Law 144 (automated employment decision tools)
- OFCCP compliance requirements for federal contractors

The standard references these frameworks for context. It is not derived from them. HCCS™ requirements are intentionally set above current regulatory floors to provide future-proof governance.

2.3 Professional and Scientific References

The following professional standards and scientific foundations inform the design of HCCS™ controls. HCCS™ is not derived from these sources but is designed to be consistent with their findings and requirements:

- SIOP Principles for the Validation and Use of Personnel Selection Procedures (5th Edition)
- Uniform Guidelines on Employee Selection Procedures (29 CFR Part 1607)
- Meehl (1954), Grove et al. (2000), Kuncel et al. (2013): actuarial vs. clinical judgment in personnel selection
- Leventhal (1980): procedural justice criteria
- Kahneman, Sibony & Sunstein (2021): noise and bias in professional judgment

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2.4 Versioning

This standard follows semantic versioning. Major versions (2.0, 3.0) indicate breaking changes to control structure. Minor versions (1.1, 1.2) add controls or clarify existing requirements without altering the framework architecture. A change log is maintained in Appendix D.

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3. Terms and Definitions

Actuarial Judgment: A decision-making approach that applies predetermined, structured criteria consistently across cases. Distinguished from clinical judgment. Research consistently demonstrates that actuarial methods outperform clinical judgment in predictive accuracy across personnel selection, risk assessment, and classification decisions (Meehl, 1954; Grove et al., 2000).

Automated Decision Tool (ADT): Any software, algorithm, or AI system that filters, scores, ranks, or recommends candidates or compensation levels without direct human input at the point of decision.

Capability: A demonstrated ability to produce a specific outcome. Distinguished from credentials (proxies for capability) and experience (time spent in a context).

Clinical Judgment: A decision-making approach that relies on the decision-maker's subjective synthesis of available information, experience, and intuition. In human capital contexts, clinical judgment includes unstructured interviews, holistic resume review, and intuitive candidate comparison. Research demonstrates that clinical judgment is systematically less accurate than actuarial methods for personnel selection decisions and more susceptible to cognitive bias.

Cognitive Bias: A systematic pattern of deviation from rational judgment in which inferences about people and situations are drawn in an illogical fashion. In human capital decisions, relevant biases include: anchoring (over-reliance on initial information), confirmation bias (seeking information that confirms a pre-existing impression), halo/horn effect (allowing one strong or weak attribute to influence overall assessment), affinity bias (preference for candidates who resemble the evaluator), contrast effects (evaluating candidates relative to the preceding candidate rather than against criteria), and primacy/recency effects (disproportionate weight given to first or last information encountered).

Compensable Factor: A measurable dimension of role scope used to determine compensation: decision authority, complexity, accountability, business impact, and required expertise.

Consequential Decision: A decision that materially affects an individual's employment status, role assignment, evaluation outcome, compensation, or access to opportunity. All controls in this standard apply to consequential decisions as defined here.

Construct Validity: The degree to which an evaluation method measures the actual capability or attribute it claims to measure. An evaluation method that correlates with job performance for reasons unrelated to the construct being assessed (e.g., verbal fluency as a proxy for technical competence) lacks construct validity. Evaluation methods used under this standard SHOULD demonstrate evidence of construct validity for the capabilities they assess.

Control: A defined requirement that governs how a process operates. A control is testable, auditable, and enforceable.

Control Failure: A documented instance where a required control was absent, bypassed, or ineffective.

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Decision Governance: The system of controls ensuring that consequential decisions are made through structured, documented, and reviewable processes.

Evidence: Documentation sufficient to demonstrate that a control was applied as specified. Evidence MUST be contemporaneous, specific, and retrievable. Evidence MUST be sufficient for an independent reviewer to reach the same conclusion based on the documented record alone.

Evaluation Integrity: The quality, relevance, and defensibility of signal used to assess candidates or role fit. Evaluation integrity requires that methods produce signal with adequate construct validity, that evaluator judgment is calibrated and consistent, and that evaluation conditions do not systematically disadvantage candidates based on characteristics unrelated to role requirements.

Human-in-the-Loop: A governance requirement that a qualified human decision-maker reviews and approves consequential outputs from automated systems before they take effect. The human reviewer MUST have sufficient authority and context to override the system and is accountable for the final decision. Passive review or rubber-stamping of automated outputs does not satisfy this requirement.

Maturity Level: A defined stage of organizational capability in implementing HCCS™ controls, ranging from Level 1 (Initial) to Level 5 (Optimizing).

Outcome-Based Role Definition: A role specification constructed around expected business outcomes, decision rights, and accountability rather than task lists or activity descriptions.

Post-Decision Rationalization: The cognitive process by which a decision-maker constructs justification for a decision after the decision has already been made, typically on the basis of intuition or preference. Post-decision rationalization produces documentation that appears structured but does not reflect the actual reasoning process. Controls in this standard require contemporaneous documentation to mitigate this threat.

Procedural Justice: The perceived fairness of the processes used to make decisions. Research (Leventhal, 1980) identifies six criteria for procedural justice: consistency (uniform application across cases), bias suppression (neutrality of decision-makers), accuracy (use of reliable information), correctability (mechanisms to appeal or review decisions), representativeness (input from affected parties), and ethicality (alignment with moral standards). HCCS™ Process Integrity controls operationalize these criteria.

Proxy: An indirect indicator used as a substitute for direct evidence. In hiring, common proxies include resumes, job titles, years of experience, and educational credentials.

Role Governance: The system of controls ensuring that roles are defined with sufficient precision to support fair evaluation, defensible hiring, and aligned compensation.

Structured Evaluation: An assessment process that uses pre-defined, role-relevant criteria applied consistently across all candidates for a given role.

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4. Core Thesis

Organizations maintain financial controls to ensure the integrity of financial decisions. Equivalent controls do not exist for human capital decisions.

HCCS™ closes that gap.

The standard addresses a systemic problem: most organizations treat hiring as a workflow rather than a decision system. Roles are poorly defined. Candidates are filtered through weak proxies. Hiring managers apply subjective judgment shaped by bias and prototype-based mental models. AI is being layered onto these flawed processes, increasing speed without improving integrity. Compensation is disconnected from role scope, tied instead to title conventions and market survey shortcuts.

The result is not simply inefficiency. It is a unified decision system, one that governs who enters the organization, how they are evaluated, how they are selected, and how they are paid, operating without formal governance, auditability, or enforceable controls.

HCCS™ provides the control structure to make these decisions evidence-based, consistent, auditable, and defensible. It applies to hiring and compensation as inseparable parts of the same decision chain.

4.1 Empirical Foundation

HCCS™ is grounded in a foundational finding from over six decades of research in forensic and organizational psychology: structured, actuarial methods consistently outperform clinical judgment in predictive accuracy across personnel selection, risk assessment, and classification decisions (Meehl, 1954; Grove et al., 2000; Kuncel, Klieger, Connelly & Ones, 2013). This finding has been replicated across hundreds of studies and is not subject to meaningful scientific dispute.

Most hiring processes rely on clinical judgment: unstructured interviews, holistic resume screening, intuitive candidate comparison, and subjective panel consensus. These methods are not simply less efficient. They are empirically less accurate, more susceptible to cognitive bias, and less defensible under audit than structured alternatives.

HCCS™ requires the shift from clinical to actuarial decision-making. Every control in this standard is designed to replace subjective, unreviewable judgment with structured, evidence-based processes that can be tested, calibrated, and audited.

The governing principle of this standard is: if the organization cannot reconstruct how a decision was made, what evidence it relied on, and whether standards were applied consistently, the process MUST be treated as unreliable.

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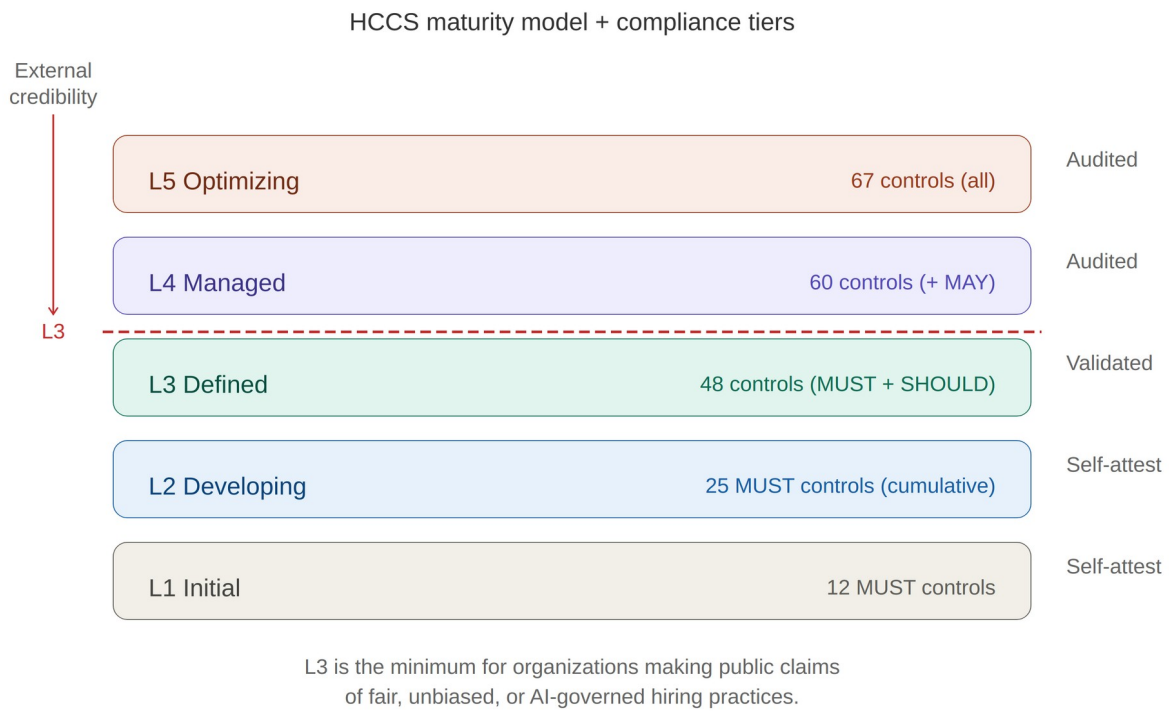
5. Maturity Model

HCCS™ defines five maturity levels. Each level represents a distinct stage of organizational capability in governing human capital decisions. Progression is cumulative: higher levels assume all requirements of lower levels are met.



The following table details each maturity level:

Level	Name	Description
1	**Initial**	Human capital processes exist but are ad hoc, inconsistent, and undocumented. Decisions rely on individual judgment. No formal controls are in place. Organizations at this level cannot reconstruct how or why a decision was made.
2	**Developing**	The organization has begun to standardize role definitions and evaluation methods. Some documentation exists but is incomplete or inconsistently applied. Awareness of control gaps exists, but remediation is in progress rather than operational.
3	**Defined**	Formal controls are documented, communicated, and applied across the organization. Role definitions are outcome-based. Evaluations use structured methods. Decisions are documented with rationale. AI tools are inventoried and subject to basic oversight. This is the minimum level for external credibility.
4	**Managed**	Controls are measured and monitored. The organization tracks

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		compliance rates, evaluator consistency, bias indicators, and decision quality. Data-driven feedback loops inform process improvement. Compensation governance is tied to verified scope analysis.
5	**Optimizing**	The organization continuously improves its human capital controls through predictive analytics, ongoing calibration, and external benchmarking. Controls are stress-tested against emerging regulations and evolving AI capabilities. The organization contributes to industry standards development.

5.1 Level Progression Requirements

An organization MUST satisfy all MUST-tagged controls at its claimed maturity level and all levels below it. An organization SHOULD satisfy all SHOULD-tagged controls at Level 3 and above. Departure from a SHOULD requirement at Level 3+ requires documented rationale demonstrating equivalent control effectiveness.

Maturity level claims MUST be supported by evidence as specified in Domain 7 (Evidence and Records Governance).

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6. Compliance Tiers

HCCS™ defines a tiered compliance model that scales accountability to organizational maturity.

Tier	Maturity Levels	Compliance Mechanism
Self-Attestation	1 and 2	The organization completes a self-assessment instrument and attests to its maturity level. No external validation is required. Self-attestation may be used for internal governance purposes but does not constitute certified compliance.
Validated Self-Assessment	3	The organization completes a self-assessment and submits evidence for independent review. A qualified assessor validates that claimed controls are documented and operational. This tier is the minimum for organizations representing HCCS™ compliance externally. It is also the minimum required for organizations making public claims of fair, unbiased, or AI-governed hiring practices.
Third-Party Audit	4 and 5	A qualified independent auditor conducts a full assessment of control design and operating effectiveness. Audit scope covers all seven control domains. The auditor issues a compliance report with findings, exceptions, and recommendations.

6.1 Qualified Assessors and Auditors

Assessors and auditors MUST demonstrate competence in human capital governance, audit methodology, and (where applicable) AI systems evaluation. Qualification criteria for assessors will be published in the HCCS™ Implementation Guide (HCCS-IG-1.0).

6.2 Compliance Period

Compliance assessments cover a 12-month period. Organizations MUST maintain evidence throughout the compliance period, not only at the point of assessment.

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7. Control Domains

HCCS™ defines seven control domains. Each domain contains numbered controls with normative requirement levels (MUST, SHOULD, MAY) and minimum maturity level applicability. Controls are cumulative: higher-level controls assume lower-level controls are in place.

Control identifiers follow the format HCCS-[Domain Code]-[Sequence Number]. These identifiers are persistent across versions and are used for cross-referencing in the Implementation Guide (HCCS-IG-1.0) and Template Library (HCCS-T-1.0).

7.1 RG: Role Governance

Purpose: Roles MUST be defined with sufficient precision to support fair evaluation, defensible hiring, and aligned compensation. Role governance controls address the root cause of downstream failure: poorly constructed role definitions.

Control Objective: Ensure that every role is defined with sufficient clarity and specificity to support consistent evaluation, defensible selection, and aligned compensation, before any candidate is sourced.

HCCS-RG-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] Every open role MUST have a documented role definition before candidate sourcing begins.

HCCS-RG-002 **[MUST]** [L1+] Role definitions MUST specify expected business outcomes, not only task lists or activity descriptions.

HCCS-RG-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] Role definitions MUST distinguish between required capabilities (necessary at hire) and learnable capabilities (developable post-hire).

HCCS-RG-004 **[MUST]** [L2+] Role definitions MUST specify decision rights and accountability boundaries.

HCCS-RG-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Role definitions SHOULD include scope indicators: complexity of decisions, span of influence, ambiguity tolerance required, and stakeholder exposure.

HCCS-RG-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Role definitions SHOULD be validated by at least one person other than the hiring manager before sourcing begins.

HCCS-RG-007 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD maintain a role taxonomy that links role definitions to compensation bands, career levels, and organizational capability maps.

HCCS-RG-008 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement role definition quality scoring to measure specificity, outcome-orientation, and alignment with organizational strategy.

HCCS-RG-009 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY conduct periodic role definition audits to identify drift between documented definitions and actual role execution.

Required Evidence

- Completed role definition documents for all open positions

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- Approval records showing pre-sourcing sign-off
- Role taxonomy documentation (Level 3+)
- Role definition quality scores (Level 4+)
- Role audit reports (Level 5)

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7.2 EI: Evaluation Integrity

Purpose: Candidate evaluation MUST produce relevant, reliable, and defensible signal about a candidate's ability to deliver the outcomes specified in the role definition. Evaluation integrity controls reduce reliance on weak proxies and improve signal quality. Every screening and evaluation decision is a classification problem with four possible outcomes: correct advancement of qualified candidates, correct screening of unqualified candidates, false advancement (advancing unqualified candidates), and missed talent (screening out qualified candidates). Evaluation integrity controls exist to maximize correct classifications and minimize both types of error.

Control Objective: Ensure that every candidate is assessed using structured, role-relevant methods that produce signal an independent reviewer would consider reliable and sufficient for the decision made. Evaluation methods SHOULD demonstrate construct validity for the capabilities they assess.

HCCS-EI-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] Evaluation criteria MUST be derived from the role definition and documented before candidate assessment begins.

HCCS-EI-002 **[MUST]** [L1+] Every candidate for a given role MUST be evaluated against the same criteria using the same methods.

HCCS-EI-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] Evaluation methods MUST assess capabilities relevant to role outcomes, not solely credentials, titles, or years of experience.

HCCS-EI-004 **[MUST]** [L2+] Evaluators MUST document their assessment rationale for each candidate using the pre-defined criteria.

HCCS-EI-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Evaluation processes SHOULD include at least one behavioral or situational assessment that reveals how the candidate operates under conditions relevant to the role (ambiguity, complexity, time pressure, stakeholder conflict).

HCCS-EI-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD calibrate evaluators by reviewing scoring patterns, testing inter-rater reliability, and addressing systematic scoring inconsistencies. Calibration SHOULD target inter-rater reliability coefficients of .70 or higher for selection-relevant criteria, consistent with established psychometric standards for personnel assessment.

HCCS-EI-007 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement structured debrief protocols that require evaluators to present evidence before sharing overall assessments, to reduce anchoring effects.

HCCS-EI-008 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY use validated psychometric instruments as supplements to, not replacements for, structured evaluation.

HCCS-EI-009 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY conduct post-hire validation studies comparing evaluation signal to on-the-job outcomes, using signal detection analysis (hit rate, miss rate, false alarm rate) to refine evaluation methods and reduce classification errors.

HCCS-EI-010 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Evaluation methods SHOULD demonstrate evidence of construct validity for the capabilities they claim to assess, consistent with the SIOP Principles for

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the Validation and Use of Personnel Selection Procedures and the Uniform Guidelines on Employee Selection Procedures. Methods that correlate with hiring outcomes for reasons unrelated to the construct being measured (e.g., verbal fluency as a proxy for technical competence) do not satisfy this requirement.

HCCS-EI-011 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD implement controls for evaluator cognitive load and decision fatigue. Evaluators SHOULD NOT assess more candidates in a single session than can be evaluated with sustained attention and consistent application of criteria. Evaluation scheduling SHOULD account for known fatigue effects on decision quality.

HCCS-EI-012 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY assess evaluation environments and conditions for stereotype threat effects, ensuring that evaluation design does not systematically disadvantage candidates based on identity characteristics unrelated to role requirements. This includes assessment format, setting, evaluator composition, and framing of evaluation tasks.

HCCS-EI-013 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY design evaluation methods to control for impression management and social desirability effects, using structured behavioral questions anchored to specific past events, work samples, or simulations that reduce the candidate's ability to substitute rehearsed narratives for demonstrated capability.

Required Evidence

- Evaluation criteria documentation linked to role definitions
- Completed candidate scorecards with documented rationale
- Evaluator calibration records with inter-rater reliability data (Level 3+)
- Construct validity documentation for evaluation methods (Level 3+)
- Evaluator scheduling and cognitive load management records (Level 3+)
- Stereotype threat assessment documentation (Level 4+)
- Impression management control documentation in evaluation design (Level 4+)
- Post-hire signal detection analysis results (Level 5)

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7.3 DG: Decision Governance

Purpose: Hiring and compensation decisions MUST be made through structured, documented, and reviewable processes. Decision governance controls address the human element of the system: the decision-makers themselves.

Control Objective: Ensure that every consequential hiring or compensation decision can be reconstructed, that the rationale references pre-defined criteria, and that the decision-maker is identifiable and accountable.

HCCS-DG-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] Every hiring decision MUST be documented with the rationale for selection, including which criteria the chosen candidate satisfied and how they compared to other evaluated candidates.

HCCS-DG-002 **[MUST]** [L1+] Selection rationale MUST reference the pre-defined evaluation criteria and MUST be documented contemporaneously with the decision. Post-hoc justification without reference to structured criteria constitutes a control failure. Rationale constructed after a decision has been reached on other grounds (post-decision rationalization) does not satisfy this requirement, regardless of its apparent quality.

HCCS-DG-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] Decision authority MUST be defined: who has final authority to approve a hire, who participates in evaluation, and what quorum or consensus model applies. The final decision-maker is accountable for both the decision outcome and the integrity of the process used to reach it.

HCCS-DG-004 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD require that decision-makers disclose potential conflicts of interest, prior relationships with candidates, or other factors that could compromise objectivity.

HCCS-DG-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD implement mechanisms to detect scoring inconsistencies, evaluator bias patterns, and systematic deviations from criteria-based assessment. Detection mechanisms SHOULD specifically monitor for: anchoring effects (first-impression dominance), confirmation bias (selective evidence weighting), halo/horn effects (single-attribute distortion), affinity bias (similarity preference), contrast effects (candidate-to-candidate rather than candidate-to-criteria comparison), and primacy/recency effects (order-dependent weighting).

HCCS-DG-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Rejection decisions for candidates who met minimum criteria SHOULD include documented rationale beyond 'not the best fit.'

HCCS-DG-007 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD implement structured debrief protocols that require evaluators to present individual evidence and scores before any group discussion or overall assessment sharing. This control mitigates conformity pressure, authority bias, anchoring to the first speaker, and groupthink in panel-based decisions. Research demonstrates this is one of the highest-impact interventions for improving group decision quality.

HCCS-DG-008 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement decision review boards or audit committees for senior-level or high-impact hiring decisions.

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HCCS-DG-009 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD implement mechanisms to distinguish contemporaneous structured rationale from post-decision rationalization. Indicators of post-decision rationalization include: rationale documented significantly after the decision event, rationale that does not reference specific evaluation criteria or evidence, and rationale that is inconsistent with documented evaluation scores. Where post-decision rationalization is detected, the decision SHOULD be flagged for review.

HCCS-DG-010 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY publish anonymized decision quality metrics, including time-to-productivity, retention correlation, evaluator accuracy rates, and classification error rates.

Required Evidence

- Hiring decision documentation with selection rationale
- Decision authority matrix with named accountable decision-makers
- Conflict of interest disclosures (Level 3+)
- Cognitive bias detection and scoring consistency reports (Level 3+)
- Structured debrief protocol documentation and compliance records (Level 3+)
- Post-decision rationalization detection mechanism documentation (Level 3+)
- Decision review board records (Level 4+)
- Published decision quality metrics with classification error rates (Level 5)

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7.4 AG: AI Governance

Purpose: AI amplifies both signal and error. Without governance, it scales flawed decisions. Any automated system used in human capital decisions MUST be transparent, explainable, subject to human oversight, and auditable. AI governance controls apply to all stages: sourcing, screening, evaluation, compensation benchmarking, and workforce planning.

Control Objective: Ensure that no automated system operates as an unreviewable decision-maker, that all ADT outputs can be reconstructed and explained, and that human oversight is substantive rather than performative.

HCCS-AG-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] The organization MUST maintain an inventory of all automated decision tools (ADTs) used in human capital processes, including vendor name, function, decision scope, and deployment date.

HCCS-AG-002 **[MUST]** [L1+] No ADT may serve as the sole decision-maker for any consequential human capital decision. A qualified human decision-maker MUST review and approve outcomes before they take effect. The reviewer MUST have sufficient authority and context to override the system and is accountable for the final decision.

HCCS-AG-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] The organization MUST be able to explain, in plain language, how each ADT produces its outputs, what data it uses, and what criteria drive its recommendations.

HCCS-AG-004 **[MUST]** [L2+] ADTs MUST be tested for disparate impact before deployment and at regular intervals thereafter.

HCCS-AG-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] The organization SHOULD disclose to candidates when ADTs are used in screening or evaluation, including a general description of the tool's function.

HCCS-AG-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] ADT outputs SHOULD be auditable: the organization SHOULD be able to reconstruct why a specific candidate was screened in or out by the tool.

HCCS-AG-007 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD designate an accountable owner for each ADT, responsible for ongoing monitoring, bias testing, and compliance.

HCCS-AG-008 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement A/B testing or parallel processing (human and ADT evaluation of the same candidates) to measure ADT accuracy and detect drift.

HCCS-AG-009 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY conduct adversarial testing of ADTs to identify failure modes, manipulation vulnerabilities, and edge cases.

HCCS-AG-010 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY contribute ADT performance data to industry benchmarking initiatives to advance cross-organizational standards for AI in human capital.

Required Evidence

- ADT inventory with function descriptions and deployment records
- Human-in-the-loop review documentation for ADT-supported decisions
- Explainability documentation for each ADT
- Disparate impact testing results and remediation records
- Candidate disclosure records (Level 3+)

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- ADT audit trail showing individual decision reconstruction capability (Level 3+)
- ADT owner designation and monitoring records (Level 3+)
- A/B testing or parallel processing results (Level 4+)
- Adversarial testing reports (Level 4+)

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7.5 PI: Process Integrity

Purpose: Hiring processes MUST operate with transparency and integrity. Process integrity controls address the structural conditions under which decisions are made, including the distinction between genuinely open processes and those where outcomes are functionally predetermined. These controls operationalize the principles of procedural justice (Leventhal, 1980): consistency of application, bias suppression, accuracy of information, correctability of outcomes, representativeness of input, and ethicality of process.

Control Objective: Ensure that every hiring process operates as represented, that candidates are evaluated consistently regardless of source, and that performative processes are identified and eliminated.

HCCS-PI-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] Every externally posted role MUST represent a genuinely open hiring process in which external candidates have a real opportunity to be selected.

HCCS-PI-002 **[MUST]** [L2+] If an internal or preferred candidate has been identified before external posting, the organization MUST document this and designate the process accordingly. Undisclosed performative external hiring processes constitute a control failure, where applicable and subject to jurisdictional requirements.

HCCS-PI-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] All candidates who advance past initial screening MUST be evaluated using the same process, criteria, and methods, regardless of referral source.

HCCS-PI-004 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD track and report the ratio of internal-preference hires to genuinely open hires, by department and level.

HCCS-PI-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Process timelines SHOULD be documented and communicated to candidates. Material deviations from stated timelines SHOULD be communicated proactively.

HCCS-PI-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD provide substantive feedback to candidates who reached final evaluation stages, beyond automated rejection notices.

HCCS-PI-007 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY conduct process integrity audits that assess candidate experience, timeline adherence, and consistency of process application across demographic groups.

HCCS-PI-008 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY publish anonymized process integrity metrics as part of employer transparency reporting.

Required Evidence

- Process designation records (open vs. internal-preference)
- Evaluation consistency records across candidate populations
- Internal-preference hire ratio reports (Level 3+)
- Candidate communication and timeline adherence records (Level 3+)
- Process integrity audit reports (Level 4+)
- Published transparency metrics (Level 5)

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7.6 CG: Compensation Governance

Purpose: Compensation MUST be aligned to the actual scope, complexity, and accountability of the role as defined in the role definition. Compensation governance controls correct the disconnect between title-based market shortcuts and the real demands of the work.

Control Objective: Ensure that compensation for every role is determined by verified compensable factors, documented with rationale, and subject to the same audit scrutiny as hiring decisions.

HCCS-CG-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] Compensation for every role MUST be determined using defined compensable factors, not solely by job title, market survey title matches, or candidate salary history.

HCCS-CG-002 **[MUST]** [L2+] Compensable factors MUST include, at minimum: decision authority, scope complexity, accountability, business impact, and required expertise.

HCCS-CG-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] The organization MUST document the rationale connecting each role's compensation to its compensable factor analysis.

HCCS-CG-004 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD conduct scope-to-compensation alignment reviews at least annually to identify roles where compensation has drifted from actual scope.

HCCS-CG-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Compensation decisions SHOULD be subject to the same documentation and audit requirements as hiring decisions.

HCCS-CG-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Organizations SHOULD analyze compensation data for pay equity across demographic groups, controlling for compensable factors.

HCCS-CG-007 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement real-time compensation modeling that adjusts when role scope changes materially.

HCCS-CG-008 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY participate in or publish compensable-factor-based benchmarking data to advance industry movement beyond title-based compensation.

Required Evidence

- Compensable factor analysis for each role
- Compensation rationale documentation linking factors to pay
- Annual scope-to-compensation alignment review results (Level 3+)
- Pay equity analysis reports (Level 3+)
- Real-time compensation model documentation (Level 4+)
- Industry benchmarking participation records (Level 5)

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7.7 ER: Evidence and Records Governance

Purpose: The organization MUST create, retain, classify, and produce records sufficient to demonstrate that all other controls were applied as specified. Without Evidence and Records Governance, every other domain's audit requirements are unenforceable.

Control Objective: Ensure that the organization can produce, on request, a complete and contemporaneous record for any human capital decision, sufficient for an independent reviewer to assess whether controls were applied as specified.

HCCS-ER-001 **[MUST]** [L1+] The organization MUST create contemporaneous records for every control-relevant decision. Retrospective reconstruction of decision rationale does not satisfy this requirement.

HCCS-ER-002 **[MUST]** [L1+] Records MUST be retained for a minimum of three years from the date of the decision or the end of the compliance period, whichever is later.

HCCS-ER-003 **[MUST]** [L2+] Records MUST be classified by control domain, decision type, and date, and be retrievable within a reasonable timeframe upon audit request.

HCCS-ER-004 **[MUST]** [L2+] The organization MUST designate accountability for records governance, including creation, storage, access, and disposal.

HCCS-ER-005 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] The organization SHOULD implement a records management system that links evidence to specific control IDs and decision events.

HCCS-ER-006 **[SHOULD]** [L3+] Access to human capital decision records SHOULD be restricted to authorized personnel and subject to access logging.

HCCS-ER-007 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY implement automated evidence collection that captures records at the point of decision without manual intervention.

HCCS-ER-008 **[MAY]** [L4+] Organizations MAY conduct records completeness audits that verify coverage across all control domains.

HCCS-ER-009 **[MAY]** [L5+] Organizations MAY implement tamper-evident or immutable record storage for high-stakes decisions.

Required Evidence

- Records governance policy with accountability designations
- Evidence of contemporaneous record creation
- Records classification and retrieval capability demonstration
- Records retention schedule
- Access control and logging records (Level 3+)
- Records management system documentation (Level 3+)
- Automated evidence collection system documentation (Level 4+)
- Records completeness audit reports (Level 4+)
- Tamper-evident storage system documentation (Level 5)

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8. Audit and Accountability

8.1 Audit Principle

If the organization cannot reconstruct how a decision was made, what evidence it relied on, and whether standards were applied consistently, the process MUST be treated as unreliable for compliance purposes.

8.2 Audit Scope

A full HCCS™ audit covers all seven control domains. The auditor assesses both design effectiveness (are controls properly designed?) and operating effectiveness (are controls functioning as designed in practice?).

8.3 Audit Outputs

An HCCS™ audit produces:

- A compliance report stating the assessed maturity level for each domain and overall
- A findings schedule documenting control deficiencies, their severity, and affected decisions
- An exceptions report documenting justified departures from SHOULD requirements
- Recommendations for control improvement

8.4 Control Failure Classification

Severity	Definition
Critical	A MUST control is absent or non-functional. The organization cannot claim compliance at any maturity level for the affected domain.
Significant	A SHOULD control is absent at Level 3+ without documented rationale, or a MUST control is operational but inconsistently applied.
Minor	A MAY practice is absent at Level 4+, or documentation is incomplete but the underlying control is operational.

8.5 Remediation

Critical findings MUST be remediated before the organization can claim or maintain its maturity level. Significant findings MUST have a documented remediation plan with a timeline not exceeding 90 days. Minor findings SHOULD be addressed within the next compliance period.

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Appendix A: Control ID Index

The following index lists all controls defined in this standard, organized by domain. Each control ID is persistent across versions.

Control ID	Level	Requirement	Summary
HCCS-RG-001	L1+	**MUST**	Documented role definition before sourcing
HCCS-RG-002	L1+	**MUST**	Outcome-based role specification
HCCS-RG-003	L2+	**MUST**	Required vs. learnable capability distinction
HCCS-RG-004	L2+	**MUST**	Decision rights and accountability specified
HCCS-RG-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Scope indicators included
HCCS-RG-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Role definition peer validation
HCCS-RG-007	L3+	**SHOULD**	Role taxonomy maintenance
HCCS-RG-008	L4+	**MAY**	Role definition quality scoring
HCCS-RG-009	L5	**MAY**	Periodic role definition audits
HCCS-EI-001	L1+	**MUST**	Evaluation criteria from role definition
HCCS-EI-002	L1+	**MUST**	Consistent criteria and methods across candidates
HCCS-EI-003	L2+	**MUST**	Capability-based assessment over proxies
HCCS-EI-004	L2+	**MUST**	Documented evaluator rationale
HCCS-EI-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Behavioral/situational assessment inclusion
HCCS-EI-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Evaluator calibration with psychometric thresholds
HCCS-EI-007	L4+	**MAY**	Evidence-before-assessment debrief protocol
HCCS-EI-008	L4+	**MAY**	Validated psychometric supplements
HCCS-EI-009	L5	**MAY**	Post-hire signal detection validation studies
HCCS-EI-010	L3+	**SHOULD**	Construct validity for evaluation methods
HCCS-EI-011	L3+	**SHOULD**	Evaluator cognitive load and fatigue controls
HCCS-EI-012	L4+	**MAY**	Stereotype threat environment assessment
HCCS-EI-013	L4+	**MAY**	Impression management controls in evaluation design
HCCS-DG-001	L1+	**MUST**	Documented selection rationale
HCCS-DG-002	L1+	**MUST**	Rationale references pre-defined criteria
HCCS-DG-003	L2+	**MUST**	Defined decision authority with accountability for outcome and process

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HCCS-DG-004	L3+	**SHOULD**	Conflict of interest disclosure
HCCS-DG-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Cognitive bias detection with named bias taxonomy
HCCS-DG-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Substantive rejection rationale
HCCS-DG-007	L3+	**SHOULD**	Structured debrief protocol (evidence before assessment)
HCCS-DG-008	L4+	**MAY**	Decision review boards
HCCS-DG-009	L3+	**SHOULD**	Post-decision rationalization detection
HCCS-DG-010	L5	**MAY**	Published decision quality metrics
HCCS-AG-001	L1+	**MUST**	ADT inventory maintained
HCCS-AG-002	L1+	**MUST**	Human-in-the-loop with override authority for all consequential decisions
HCCS-AG-003	L2+	**MUST**	Plain-language ADT explainability
HCCS-AG-004	L2+	**MUST**	Disparate impact testing
HCCS-AG-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Candidate ADT disclosure
HCCS-AG-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	ADT output auditability
HCCS-AG-007	L3+	**SHOULD**	Designated ADT owner
HCCS-AG-008	L4+	**MAY**	ADT accuracy A/B testing
HCCS-AG-009	L4+	**MAY**	Adversarial ADT testing
HCCS-AG-010	L5	**MAY**	Industry ADT benchmarking contribution
HCCS-PI-001	L1+	**MUST**	External postings represent genuinely open processes
HCCS-PI-002	L2+	**MUST**	Internal-preference processes documented and designated
HCCS-PI-003	L2+	**MUST**	Consistent evaluation regardless of referral source
HCCS-PI-004	L3+	**SHOULD**	Internal-preference hire ratio tracking
HCCS-PI-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Documented and communicated process timelines
HCCS-PI-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Substantive feedback for final-stage candidates
HCCS-PI-007	L4+	**MAY**	Process integrity audits
HCCS-PI-008	L5	**MAY**	Published process transparency metrics
HCCS-CG-001	L1+	**MUST**	Compensable-factor-based pay determination
HCCS-CG-002	L2+	**MUST**	Minimum compensable factors defined
HCCS-CG-003	L2+	**MUST**	Documented compensation rationale

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HCCS-CG-004	L3+	**SHOULD**	Annual scope-to-compensation alignment review
HCCS-CG-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Compensation decision audit requirements
HCCS-CG-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Pay equity analysis
HCCS-CG-007	L4+	**MAY**	Real-time compensation modeling
HCCS-CG-008	L5	**MAY**	Industry compensable-factor benchmarking
HCCS-ER-001	L1+	**MUST**	Contemporaneous record creation
HCCS-ER-002	L1+	**MUST**	Three-year minimum records retention
HCCS-ER-003	L2+	**MUST**	Records classification and retrievability
HCCS-ER-004	L2+	**MUST**	Designated records governance accountability
HCCS-ER-005	L3+	**SHOULD**	Records linked to control IDs
HCCS-ER-006	L3+	**SHOULD**	Access restriction and logging
HCCS-ER-007	L4+	**MAY**	Automated evidence collection
HCCS-ER-008	L4+	**MAY**	Records completeness audits
HCCS-ER-009	L5	**MAY**	Tamper-evident record storage

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Appendix B: Maturity Level Requirements Matrix

This matrix summarizes the cumulative requirements at each maturity level across all domains.

Level 1: Initial	Level 2: Developing	Level 3: Defined	Level 4: Managed	Level 5: Optimizing
All L1 MUST controls operational	All L1+L2 MUST controls operational	All MUST controls operational. All SHOULD controls operational or documented departures.	All MUST and SHOULD controls operational. MAY controls actively considered and implemented where applicable.	All controls operational. Continuous improvement, external benchmarking, and predictive governance in place.
Self-attestation	Self-attestation	Validated self-assessment	Third-party audit	Third-party audit
12 MUST controls	12 + 13 MUST controls (25 total)	25 MUST + 23 SHOULD controls (48 total)	48 + 12 MAY controls (60 total)	60 + 7 MAY controls (67 total)

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Appendix C: Regulatory Cross-Reference

This appendix maps HCCS™ control domains to existing regulatory frameworks. HCCS™ is designed to exceed these requirements. This mapping is provided for reference, not derivation.

HCCS™ Domain	Title VII / EEOC	EU AI Act	NYC LL144	OFCCP
RG	Job-relatedness requirement	High-risk system documentation	N/A	Job analysis requirements
EI	Validation standards	Accuracy and robustness	N/A	Selection procedure validation
DG	Non-discrimination in selection	Human oversight	N/A	Record-keeping requirements
AG	Adverse impact testing	Transparency and explainability	Bias audit requirement	Systemic discrimination analysis
PI	Equal opportunity requirements	N/A	N/A	Outreach and recruitment
CG	Equal Pay Act alignment	N/A	N/A	Compensation non-discrimination
ER	Record retention (1-2 years)	Technical documentation	Published audit results	Record retention (2 years)

Note: HCCS™ record retention requirements (3 years minimum) exceed all listed regulatory minimums. HCCS™ AI governance controls exceed NYC LL144 requirements in scope (all ADTs, not only AEDT), transparency (candidate disclosure), and oversight (human-in-the-loop for all consequential decisions).

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Appendix D: Version History and Change Log

Version	Date	Author	Description
1.0	March 2026	Diane Malefyt	Initial release. 7 control domains, 67 controls, 5-level maturity model, tiered compliance framework. Grounded in forensic and organizational psychology: actuarial vs. clinical judgment, cognitive bias taxonomy, procedural justice, signal detection theory, and construct validity.

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Appendix E: References

The following sources inform the scientific and professional foundations of this standard. References are organized by category.

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